PROBLÈME · ANNALES SPÉ · 35 MIN

To what extent should ethical eating be encouraged ?

Même article (Beyond Meat, *The Financial Express*, 2023).

Sales at vegan burger maker Beyond Meat fall by almost a third

It launched with the promise to "eat what you love", but consumers' love affair with Beyond Meat's pricey meat substitutes is waning. Quarterly sales at the vegan burger maker have slumped by almost a third as shoppers shift away from expensive meat substitutes amid the cost of living crisis.

The US company, whose plant-based products include "burgers that appear to bleed" and imitations of sausages and meatballs, has cut its annual revenue forecast in the latest sign that the fake meat food bubble is bursting. After several years of rapid expansion fuelled by a splurge of private equity investment, meat substitutes have dropped off many menus. Sales unexpectedly slid 6% in the UK last year.

Vegan specialists including Meatless Farm of Leeds and Lincolnshire-based Plant & Bean, which supplied companies including Quorn and Tesco's Wicked Kitchen, called in administrators earlier this year as they battled lacklustre sales and hefty cost increases. Meanwhile, Sweden's Oatly, the Swiss food company Nestlé and the London-based Innocent Drinks, which is owned by Coca-Cola, are among those that have pulled vegan products from sale in the UK this year.

As the cost of living crisis has put pressure on household budgets, shoppers have turned to cheaper proteins including processed meat and traditional vegan or vegetarian options such as chickpeas, lentils and beans.

Alice Pilkington, a food analyst at Mintel, said people expected that cutting down on meat would save them money but the price of fake meat products was becoming "increasingly a barrier as they were on a par or more expensive than meat or more traditional alternatives".

Enthusiasm has also been dampened by concerns about the highly processed nature of some fake meats, highlighted by recent investigations into the health impacts of ultra-processed foods, as well as a shift towards cooking from scratch using basic ingredients during the Covid pandemic lockdowns.

Ethan Brown, the chief executive of Beyond Meat, said the ambiguity around the health benefits of eating plant-based meat had held back sales. "This change in perception is not without encouragement from interest groups who have succeeded in seeding doubt and fear around the ingredients and process used to create our and other plant-based meats," he said. The company is now forecasting that sales will fall by at least 9% this year to no more than $380m, down from previous hopes of up to $415m.

Adapted from The Financial Express, August 28, 2023

1. In your opinion, to what extent should ethical and sustainable eating be further encouraged ? (180 words, ± 10%)